

AI OPERATIONS

Your AI report ran. The inputs changed.

Nobody told the AI. It produced clean output on broken inputs anyway.

The fix is not a better model. It is an input contract.

A recurring report earns trust from last week. Not this week's inputs.

- A one-time report gets reviewed. You catch the obvious problems.
- A recurring report gets trusted on sight. Nobody checks the inputs.
- The data underneath the automation is still touched by humans every week.

When the input changes and the prompt does not know, the AI improvises. Silently.

CONTRACT SECTION 1

Required columns. Exact names.

Name every column the AI needs. Case-sensitive.

If a required column is missing or renamed, the AI stops and flags it. It does not improvise around the gap.

This catches roughly sixty percent of silent drift failures. Most people skip it because they assume the export will not change.

CONTRACT SECTION 2

Name the fields that are allowed to be blank.

Without this, every empty cell is ambiguous.

The AI treats missing data as a problem to solve. It applies an assumption you did not authorize. Quietly.

Ambiguous cells produce silent improvisation. Silent improvisation produces wrong numbers with no flag.

CONTRACT SECTION 3

Date format plus a calculation check before any trend runs.

- Specify the expected date format. Name which column is the date column.
- Compute the span from first date to last date. If it is off from expected by more than a day, stop.
- A shifted date format means your week-over-week comparison is comparing the wrong weeks.

Two lines of instruction that save a presentation.

CONTRACT SECTION 4

Three lines at the end of every run.

- | What the input file contained
- | What changed from last run
- | What the AI assumed or approximated

When a trend looks wrong six weeks from now, you debug from evidence. Not from memory.

THE CONTRACT IN PRACTICE

Four sections. Sits above your existing prompt.

- | Required columns with exact names
- | Optional fields and what blank means
- | Date format and calculation check
- | Run log instruction

One session to write. Runs every week after that. No new platform. No developer.

full/REFIT

Get the Recurring-Report Input Contract template.

Four sections, copy-paste ready. Fill in your column names and date format once. Your report flags broken inputs every week after that.

Get the free template

(Link in the first comment)